

Hypervisibility and Invisibility: Anti-Asian Racism in Germany

Hyunjung Lee
Asian Voices Europe
asianvoiceseurope@gmail.com

Seminar Ausgewählte Schwerpunkte im Bereich Interkulturelle Psychologie
Universität Duisburg-Essen

November 4, 2025



Asian Voices Europe

ASIAN VOICES EUROPE

- ★ Our initial actions were
 - to call for a centralized **hotline** at the national/EU level
 - to provide **community-building** and peer-to-peer **psycho-social support** during lockdown
- ★ Started in March 2020 with an *ad hoc* survey documenting hate crimes during the Covid-19 pandemic.
- included in the report of *Corona en discriminatiemeldingen in Nederland*
- ★ Our main goal is to **facilitate communication and dialogue on the subject of anti-Asian racism (AAR)** as well as to promote cultural diversity in Europe.

Asian: Forever foreigners or honorary white?

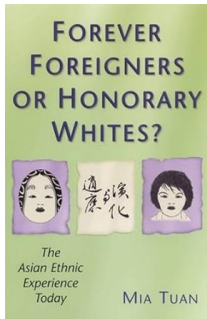


Figure 1: Mia Tuan, 1999

When I hear the phrase “*Asians are next in line to be White*,” I replace the word “White” with “disappear.” *Asians are next in line to disappear*. We are reputed to be so accomplished, and so law-abiding, we will disappear into this country’s amnesiac fog. We will not be the power but become absorbed by power, [...] we’re often listed as “*Other*” in polls and why we’re hard to find in racial breakdowns on reported rape or workplace discrimination or domestic abuse. (Hong 2021: 35)

Questions:

- ★ What are the forms and expressions of contemporary racism in Germany, particularly as experienced by Asian diaspora?
- ★ How does the recognition of racism often meet resistance or denial in public discourse?
- ★ How can diasporic movement and their allies mobilize to combat racism and foster public awareness?

The Roadmap

- 1 Overview
- 2 AAR
- 3 Persistence of AAR
- 4 Anti-racis initiatives

A long (but less documented) history of anti-Asian racism in Germany

Anti-Asian racism (AAR) existed in Germany before COVID-19; among the worst outbreaks of anti-Asian violence since 1945 have been the racist riots in Hoyerswerda in 1991 and in the Lichtenhagen district of Rostock in 1992. [...] A particular feature of AAR is that it also operates with the “model immigrant” myth who are often played off against other groups in racist discourse. [...] Little is known as yet about the extent to which Asian [diaspora] are subject to structural racism, as there are scarcely any relevant studies.

(Federal Government Commissioner for Anti-Racism 2023: 39)

- ★ AAR was not even officially recognized as a distinct category of racism by Germany until November 2023 (European Commission 2020a,b, Asian Voices Europe 2024, European Commission 2024, Suda and Köhler 2024).

Experience of Discrimination by Asian Diaspora

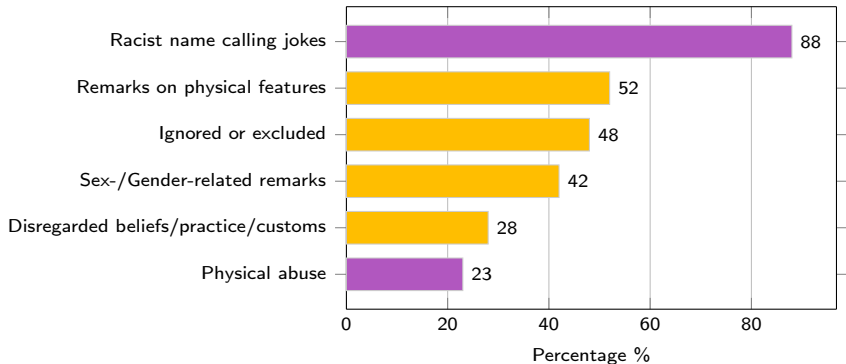


Figure 3: What kind of racial harassment have you experienced?

★ Reported AAR incidents most frequently occurred on the streets (71%), public transport (61%), but also in educational institutions (14%) and the work place (25%).

Physical assault

- (1) It was Christmas Eve in 2022, around 13:00 in the afternoon. I was walking my dog in a residential area in Duisburg. Suddenly, two men approached me. They looked straight at me and started shouting, calling me a **disgusting Chinese** and saying they would **kill every Chinese**. Before I could react, one of them **punched me in the face**. I stumbled, trying to protect my dog. My head and left eye were injured. I screamed for help, and some people nearby called the police. The two men ran away before the police arrived. They were never caught.
- 20s, man*
(News 2022)

Physical assault

- (2) When I told my daughter's kindergarten about racist remarks other children made toward her, they suggested we [find another school where there are more Asians](#). [...] On the street, people sometimes shout [Hey Corona](#) or [Ching chong](#) at us. My daughter doesn't yet understand what those words mean, but I worry for the day she does.
30s, women, Germany ([Asian Voices Europe 2024](#))

Media representation



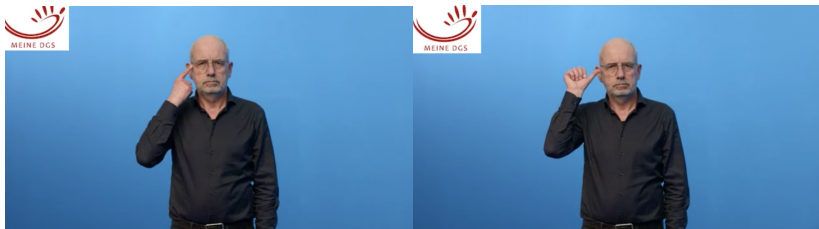
Figure 5: 06.03.2020: ZDF Heute Show,
"Ching Chang Chong Leer ist der Karton"



Figure 6: Three Chinese Men with a Double Bass. Kamishibai Picture Card Set

★ The chant relies on a **pseudo-Chinese gibberish**, mocks languages spoken in Asia and Asian's appearance, teach children racialized stereotypes as humor, and reproduce a **colonial gaze on Asianness**.

Sign languages



Asiat, Asiatin, 'Asia(n)' in German Sign Language (deutsche Gebärdensprache)
Löffler et al. (2020)

Microaggression; invalidaiton



Figure 7: Poster by [Leh Hwang](#)

Frequency of Racial Discrimination and Harassment

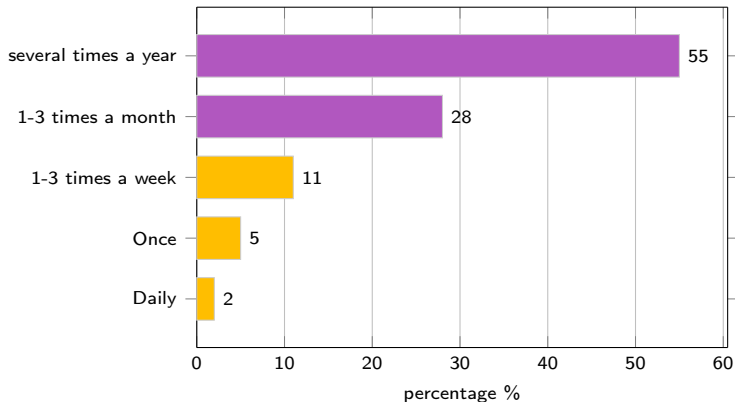


Figure 8: How many times/often have you been harassed?

Frequency of Racial Discrimination and Harassment



Dismissal of the case by the public prosecutor's office

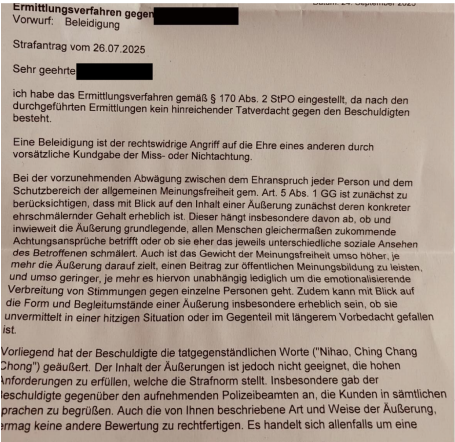


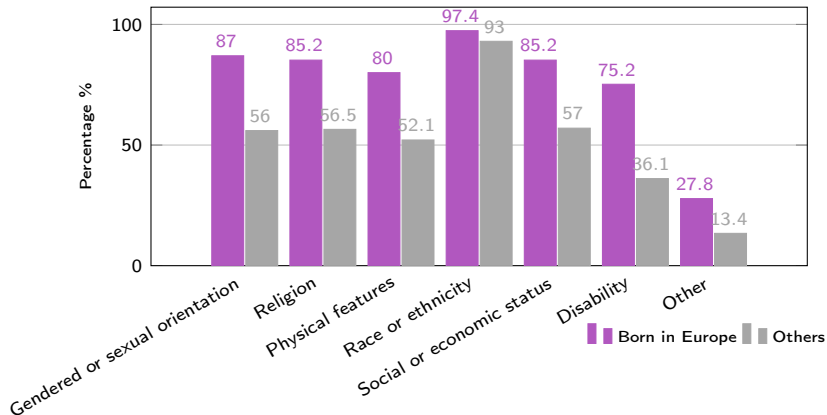
Figure 10: Criminal complaint by @2020notok



Figure 11: Poster by [Leh Hwang](#)

Experience of Discrimination by Asian Diaspora

This suggests that those who have lived in Europe for a longer period of time are more likely to be exposed to situations of racism and discrimination.



Gendered Discriminatory Experiences

The AAR trends have **intersectional** faces: **Women & Non-binary and gender diverse (NBGD)** groups more often, severely experience racism and discrimination.

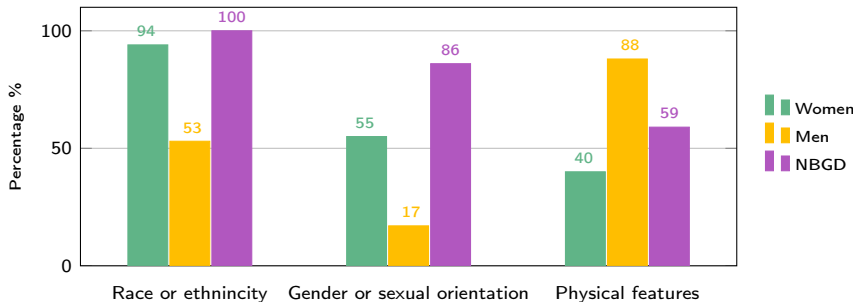


Figure 13: How do individuals across gender groups experience the top 3 forms of discrimination?

Gendered Discriminatory Experiences

Sexual and gender-based violence experienced by Asians also exhibits gendered patterns in four European countries.

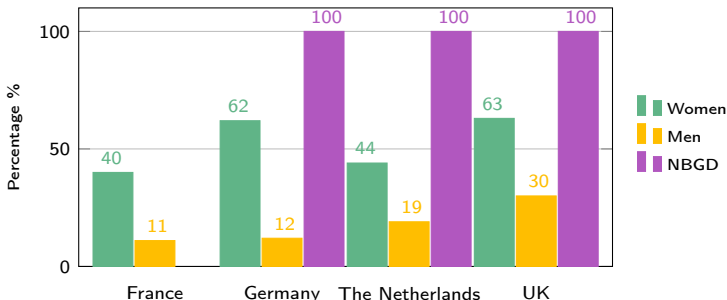


Figure 14: SGBV experienced by gender in four European countries

Gendered Discriminatory Experiences

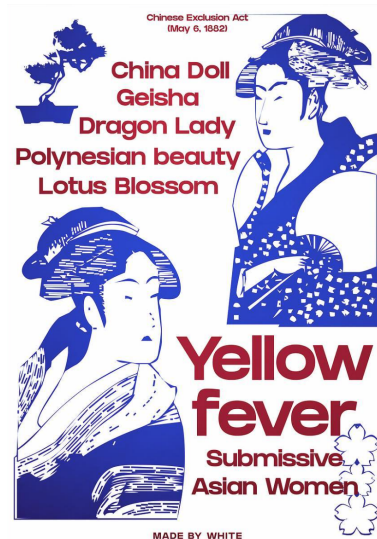
Country	EU Survey (2017) [†]	AVE Survey II (2021)
The Netherlands	44.9%	44%
France	44%	40%
United Kingdom	43.9%	62%
Germany	35.1%	63%
EU average	33%	50%

[†] Violence; Gender Equality Index, [European Institute for Gender Equality, \(2017\)](#)

Figure 15: Comparison of Sexual and Gender-Based Violence Index

cf. See [Aldemir \(2024\)](#) for sexism and racism in NL

Gendered Racism



A Long But Undocumented History of AAR in Europe

- ★ While AAR has become more visible to Whites* since the Covid-19 pandemic, colonial biases and stereotypical portraits of Asian diasporas living in Europe have predated a long ago

(Yeh 2020, Roberto et al. 2020, Chen and Wu 2021, Köhler and Suda 2023, Mai 2020, Suda et al. 2020)

* See Painter (2020, 2011) for the capitalized use of White. White does not refer to a biological characteristic, but rather a **social and political construct within a racially structured society**. Whiteness is associated with white privilege, and members of this group are considered the unmarked **norm**.

Racialized hegemony

- ★ This dual portrayal, encompassing both the 'Yellow Peril' and 'model minority' myths, draws from **orientalist narratives deeply rooted in Europe's** (post-)colonial history
(Cho 2021, Hasunuma 2020, Kawai 2005, Shim 1998, Li and Nicholson Jr 2021).
- ★ These narratives, acting as instruments of **hegemony**, reinforce simplistic stereotypes and overlook varied experiences of Asians in Europe (De Cook and Yoon 2021, Yeh 2014, De Leon 2020).

Normalization of embodied racism



Figure 17: Poster by Leh Hwang

Normalization of embodied racism

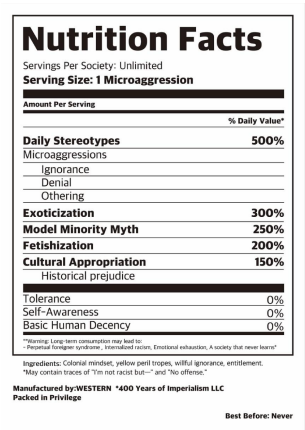


Figure 18: Poster by [Leh Hwang](#)

Microaggressions are not abstract offenses but embodied racialized experiences that influence how individuals repeatedly perceive themselves and navigate their identities ([Lee et al. nd](#)).

Neo-Racism

- ★ The **persistence** of racial discrimination **reinforces** new form of racism and social dominance.
"[R]ather, racialized identities embedded in other salient social categories such as migration status, religion, or cultural heritage" (Juang et al. 2021: 186).
- ★ The **systematic denial of AAR** disrupts inclusive societal structures by positioning Asian individuals as outsiders to the discourse on racism. They are not recognized as equal participants in this social dialogue, and their voices are often **dismissed or minimized**.
- ★ It may turn out as a **neo-racism** where traditional racial hierarchies are recast as narratives of incompatibility, **maintaining the same exclusionary racial ideologies** while escaping direct references to the discredited idea of biological race (Balibar and Wallerstein 1991, Wolgast and Wolgast 2024)

Anti-Racist Initiatives

- ★ One of the adverse consequences of anti-racist mainstreaming is that **policies are decontextualized from the lived experience of racialized peoples** and promotes a 'universalized vision of equality' (Lentin 2004: 439).
- ★ Crenshaw emphasizes that if anti-racist initiatives only articulate racism along particular dimensions, anti-racist efforts employ '**strategic silence**' (Crenshaw 1991: 1253), alerting that such interventions frequently perpetuate these silences.
- ★ The superficial antiracist actions can unintentionally reinforce racism when they **coexist with denial**. In other words, saying '*I'm not racist*' without acknowledging structural racism helps immunize racism against critique. That's a dissonance we see often: *antiracist opinions without antiracist accountability*.

ANTI RACISM

Boot Disk
Racism 99 Series
1.44MB

Setup Instructions:

1. Turn off your Stereotype.
2. Insert the Boot Disk in drive A.
3. Turn on your openness.
4. Follow the setup instructions
On the screen.

DO MAKE ILLEGAL COPIES

© 1999 Not oK
All rights reserved

MS-DOS

Version 2.0

◀ ◻ ▶ ◀ ◻ ▶ ◀ ≡ ▶ ◀ ≡ ▶ ≡ ≡ ≡ ≡ ↺ 🔍 ↻

Thank you!

We would like to express our deepest gratitude to all of the respondents for sharing their opinions and experiences with us, to all volunteers for their amazing works and to AVE supports for their support and solidarity.

asianvoiceseurope@gmail.com



Your support helps us cover **small but essential costs** like mailbox, monthly maintenance for banking accounts, domain hosting, so we can stay **independent, sustainable, and community-driven**.

AVE club

Together, we are stronger. We need you.



References

- Federal Government Commissioner for Anti-Racism (2023). *Racism in Germany: Current situation, fields of action, measures*. Federal Government Commissioner for Migration, Refugees, and Integration.
- Hartlep, N. D. and Bui, P. (2020). Vietnamese Students and the Emerging Model Minority Myth in Germany. In Steinberg, S. R. and Down, B., editors, *Handbook of critical pedagogies*, pages 518–536. SAGE Publications Ltd.
- Hasunuma, L. (2020). We are All Chinese Now: COVID-19 and Anti-Asian Racism in the United States. *The Asia-Pacific Journal*, 18(14):1–8.
- Hong, C. P. (2021). *Minor feelings: an Asian American reckoning*. One World: London.
- Hsia, J. (1988). *Asian Americans in higher education and at work*. Lawrence Erlbaum Associates, Inc.
- Juang, L. P., Moffitt, U., Schachner, M. K., and Pevec, S. (2021). Understanding ethnic-racial identity in a context where “race” is taboo. *Identity*, 21(3):185–199.
- Kawai, Y. (2005). Stereotyping Asian Americans: The dialectic of the model minority and the yellow peril. *The Howard Journal of Communications*, 16(2):109–130.
- Keevak, M. (2011). *Becoming yellow*. Princeton University Press.
- Kim, T. J. and Steinhilper, E. (2025). On the limits of antiracism: how antiracist opposition is connected to racism denial in germany. *Ethnic and Racial Studies*, pages 1–19.

Refereces

- Köhler, J. and Suda, K. (2023). Erste Ergebnisse der Studie “Antiasiatischer Rassismus in Zeiten der Corona-Pandemie”.
<https://www.dezim-institut.de/publikationen/publikation-detail/erste-ergebnisse-der-studie-antiasiatischer-rassismus-in-zeiten-der-corona-pandemie/>.
- Lee, H., Shim, S., and Seong-Yu, J. (to appear). The invisible and the hypervisible: anti-asian racism and historico-racial schema.
<https://hyunjungdotlee.github.io/files/LeeShimSeong-Yu2024.pdf>.
- Lentin, A. (2004). Racial states, anti-racist responses: Picking holes in ‘culture’ and ‘human rights’. *European Journal of Social Theory*, 7(4):427–443.
- Li, Y. and Nicholson Jr, H. L. (2021). When “model minorities” become “yellow peril” - Othering and the racialization of Asian Americans in the COVID-19 pandemic. *Sociology Compass*, 15(2):e12849.
- Löffler, J., Molzer, R., and Rasch, C. J. (2020). Gender-fair language in the translation of signed utterances in the dgs-korpus project.
- Mai, H. H. A. (2020). Anti-asiatischer Rassismus in Zeiten der Corona-Pandemie. In *Kontinuitäten und neue Perspektiven: 30 Jahre IDA: Von der Antirassismuserbeit zur Rassismuskritischen Bildungsarbeit*, volume 30, pages 24–27. Düsseldorf: Düssel-Druck & Verlag GmbH Düsseldorf.
- News, Y. (2022). “Korean student in Germany assaulted by two men in apparent hate crime”.
<https://koreajoongangdaily.joins.com/2022/12/28/national/socialAffairs/korea-asian-hate-asian-hate-crime/20221228165648622.html>. Accessed: 2022-12-28.

References

- Painter, N. I. (2011). *Standing at Armageddon: A grassroots history of the progressive era*. WW Norton & Company.
- Painter, N. I. (2020). Why 'White' should be capitalized, too. <https://www.washingtonpost.com/opinions/2020/07/22/why-white-should-be-capitalized/>. In: Washington Post, Accessed: 2023-07-29.
- Roberto, K. J., Johnson, A. F., and Rauhaus, B. M. (2020). Stigmatization and prejudice during the covid-19 pandemic. *Administrative Theory & Praxis*, 42(3):364–378.
- Shim, D. (1998). From yellow peril through model minority to renewed yellow peril. *Journal of Communication Inquiry*, 22(4):385–409.
- Spiewak, M. (2009). Das vietnamesische Wunder. <https://www.zeit.de/2009/05/B-Vietnamesen>. Die Zeit, Accessed: 2009-01-22.
- Suda, K. and Köhler, J. (2024). *Antiasiatischer Rassismus in Zeiten der Pandemie: Hintergründe, Kontexte und empirische Ergebnisse*. Berlin, DeZIM.
- Suda, K., Mayer, S. J., and Nguyen, C. (2020). Antiasiatischer Rassismus in Deutschland. *Aus Politik und Zeitgeschichte*, 70(42/44).
- Tagesschau (2025). Merz' Problem mit dem "Stadtbeeld". <https://www.tagesschau.de/inland/innenpolitik/merz-stadtbeeld-migration-100.html>. Accessed: 2025-10-17.
- Takagi, D. Y. (1992). *The retreat from race: Asian-American admissions and racial politics*. Rutgers University Press.

Appendix A: Impact of Pandemic

Our findings suggest that while the pandemic may have acted as a trigger and exacerbated AAR, it is not the sole or ultimate cause of racism against Asians in Europe.

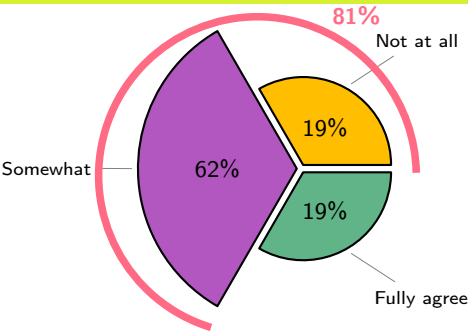


Figure 20: To what extent do you believe the racism you experienced in the last 12 months was the result of the pandemic?

Appendix C: EU's National Action Plan against Racism

- ★ The National Action Plan against Racism (NAPAR) 2020–2025 was adopted in response to structural racism as [the first](#) comprehensive action plan at [the EU level](#).



Structural racism persists in our societies. Discrimination on the basis of race or ethnic origin – as well as religion or belief – remains widespread, as shown in numerous reports. [...] [It is not enough to be against racism. We need to talk about racism. We have to be active against it.](#) (European Commission 2020b: 1,16, 19)

Appendix D: Verbal Abuse/Microaggression

- (4) a. Some people shouted at me “Nihao,” “Ching Chang Chong,” and other [derogatory] comments at me [in a] mocking [way]. - 20s, woman, in Germany (Asian Voices Europe 2024)
- b. It's so routine to hear the words “Hey Chin[ese] or Nihao” in a mocking [tone] countless times [...] Sometimes I was walking down the street and people shouted [at] me “Konichiwa!” or “Foreigner!” - 40s, woman, in the Netherlands (Asian Voices Europe 2024)
- c. Irrespective of the pandemic, [even] before the pandemic, it was very annoying to be ridiculed in France for the gestures by [slanting] eyes or making [fun of] by people [who used to] be good friends. -30s, woman, in France (Asian Voices Europe 2024)

